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35 Poems of John Muconto

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FOREWORD

this collection began as a gift to myself—
something I wanted to complete before turning 35.

it became a way of gathering fragments of a life lived:
memories, reflections, contradictions, and moments
of clarity.

not as an attempt to find answers,
and not as a search for closure,
but as a record of experience as it is.

these poems do not aim to explain life,
but to observe it—honestly, imperfectly, and
personally.

at 35, I do not claim resolution.
only awareness.

Part I — FORMATION

Live, Dear Devil, Adulthood, Dear God, Onions,
Mindfulness, Spiderman Toy, Without You, Growing
Up

Part II — STRUGGLE

Programmer's Code, Am I a Fool (Love), Pain, Erica
Startup Paradigm, Winner, School, Fuck

Part III — RELEASE

Letting Go, Parents, Beer, Nights, Poem
In a Bad Day, Sex, Babel Tower, Joy of Others,
Life Is Hard

Part IV — OBSERVATION

5 AM, Social Media Adventure, Night Sky, Johrei

Part V — RESOLUTION

Milestones of Life, Three Gifts, Peace, 35

FORMATION

Live

Live today
like the first,
like the last day of your life

with the wonder
of a child discovering
the world,
and the gaze of an elder
reminiscing on old days

Live today—
it may be the first,
it will be the last

Every day, life begins
where life ends:
a circle of life

Dear Devil

I am sorry
for every time
I blamed you

for the wrongs in the world
and in my life

for my own mistakes,
my own sins

even when
I knew exactly
what I was doing

Adulthood

When life moves too fast
and everything happens at once,

a slow day at home—
waking up late,
a cup of coffee—

is all you ask for

and then you know:
you are an adult

Dear God

Thank you for everything—
the good and the bad,
blessings and trials

I am too immature
to fully understand
your wisdom
and your love

When perfection
embraces imperfection,
there is true love

I am here for you,
as you have always
been for us

Onions

I don't like onions—
why, I can't say

the taste, the smell,
I can't take it

I don't like onions,
and neither do my father
and my brother—

something we share
without knowing why

Mindfulness

The mind wanders
through memories
and plans—

never here,
always in the past
or the future

The mind wanders,
never stops—
thoughts running
even in sleep

a tired mind

Take a deep breath,
notice what is here—

this moment
is enough

Spiderman Toy

I wanted a Spiderman action figure,
like the ones you see in commercials

I asked my mother for one
but she brought me another

I was sad—
it was not the one I wanted

but now I understand—
she did her best

she did not know Spiderman
as much as I did

it wasn't because she didn't want to

memories like this
make me appreciate my mother
and what I had

Without You

Silence screams
in the space you left—

louder
than any noise

I miss you

Growing Up

Until 10,
I wanted things

until 20,
I wanted friends

until 30,
I wanted happiness

as I grow toward 40,
I want peace of mind

as I grew, I got what I wanted—
and still reached for something deeper

in my journey through life,
I am no longer chasing—
only understanding

STRUGGLE

Programmer's Code

Between classes and objects,
organize your code

don't repeat yourself,
write readable code

know when to use
enums and interfaces

so much complexity—
maybe I should go functional

clean code or not,
it just needs to work

because if I come back in six months,
I need to find
that damn method

I believe in love

Am I a fool, to believe in love
when the world sees you as a tool

Am I a fool, to believe in love
when money, pleasure, and ego
run the world

Am I a fool, to believe in love
when everyone feels unlove

Am I a fool, to believe in love
I can't, I won't
let love die

I believe in love

to love and be loved—
no better feeling

I believe in love
only love can unite us

Pain

I feel your pain
you are not alone
I have been there before

hopeless,
in a pool of tears and sorrow

no matter what you are going through,
you will survive it
you are stronger than it

I have been there
and I survived it

there is no pain we cannot endure
and overcome

together we are stronger
it is okay to ask for help

Erica

Since our first date,
I knew you were the one

five years later,
you are still the one

I love you—
deeply,
more than before

Startup Paradigm

They say
to build a startup,
find a problem,
create a solution,

find people willing to pay,
and make the world
a better place

But what can I do
when the problem
I want to solve
is putting money
in my pocket

and escaping
the nine to five—

is that a problem
worth solving?

Winner

I lost
and I won

I lost more
than I can admit

you could say
I am a winner
at losing

the few times I won
were because
of my losses

I lost so much
I had nothing to lose

I lost
the fear of failing

School

Not much to reminisce
about school—

except colleagues
and some teachers

on those hot days,
the only thing I cared about
was getting good grades

Fuck

so much power
in a four-letter word

a word that plays
well with any other word
in any mood

embarrassed to say,
it is my favorite
little word

in the English language

RELEASE

Letting Go

From memories,
feelings, dreams,
people—
and everything else
that belonged
to who I was
in that moment
letting go
to move, to grow,
to succeed

letting go
to lose control
letting go
and leave it
in God's hands
letting go
of myself—
for something
greater

Parents

I know
all you did,
all you could,
all you knew—
for me
I love you
very much

Poem

I am not a poet,
but something in me is

my heart speaks in poems,
things even I am not aware of

the language of poets
lets me find a part of me so deep
it is only revealed through verse

Beer

that first sip was awful,

until it became

part of everything

in social moments,

it made everything easier—

until it didn't

I remember those days,

when nothing needed

to be made special

hangovers were tough,

we broke up so many times

as I grow,

I don't need you—

but the bitter taste turned sweet

I still take a sip

every now and then

Nights

quiet night,

mind clears

like a clear sky

with a full moon

good ideas come

when everyone is gone

to think, to study,

or just listen

to bossa nova

sleep leaves me alone

with myself

and returns

with the sunrise

my best sleep

is during the day

In a Bad Day

on a bad day,
sitting on the stairs,
an old man out of nowhere
greets me warmly

I forget why I was even mad

as I think back to that moment,
the cause and the old man
become mere fogs—

but the feeling remains vivid,
like a blue sky
on a summer day

Sex

casual, for pleasure
or for love

for myself or my partner
nevertheless

I still feel connected
to each one

Babel Tower

As humans, the only time
we were truly united
was when we built the tower
to become legends

with all His power,
divided by verb

ever since, families, empires,
and countries were born—
through illusory lines
that never truly existed

we achieve so much on our own,
and yet we reach our limits

if we are to survive,
we need to unite once again

to reach ourselves—

Joy of Others

that joy
that comes
from within

when you help
somebody
and see
a smile
on their face

makes me feel
holy

Life Is Hard

life is hard,
the world is harsh

for most, it is more
surviving
than living

we hold on
to little sparks of hope
to endure the day

you don't know
where it comes from—
prayer, a game,
or social media

a smile
or a hug
from someone you love

OBSERVATION

5 AM

as the sun rises,
birds sing

midnight silence
fades away

a new day begins

after all these years,
it is still easier
to go to sleep
than to wake up
at 5 AM

Social Media Adventure

started on MySpace
tasted Badoo
never a Twitter man

dated with Facebook
while cheating with Instagram

private on WhatsApp
but hiding on Reddit

between reels and shorts,
when I want an unsocial distraction

YouTube for dinner
no TikTok for me—
I've seen enough

Night Sky

when I look
at the sky
full of stars and the moon

I feel the immensity
of the universe
in a single moment

one single star
touches my heart
with light each night

until I learned
it was Venus

Johrei

the light that saved my life
even after 22 years

with humility,
I sometimes feel
unworthy to channel
God's love

I ask for permission
and lift my hand
for the person next to me

and in that moment
I feel closer to God

RESOLUTION

Milestones of Life

In life there are moments
we cannot go back from

milestones that mark our lives
for better or worse

that shape our growth

for me, what comes to mind:

the decision to let go and move on
the decision to follow God's will
rather than my own

the decision to marry the one I love
the decision to become a father
to my child

the decision to follow my dreams

Three Gifts

before birth,
wherever we stay
before coming into this world,
three gifts are given
to each of us

a talent,
a sin,
and a challenge

the talent—
something only you can do
in your own way

the sin—
one of the seven
that follows you
through life

the challenge—
something you must conquer
each day,

knowing it will never
be easy

three gifts
that make every life
unequal,
special,
human
that is life
in a nutshell

Peace

during this life
I searched for it all—

happiness
in people, things, and success

love
in people, in things,
and in myself

through suffering,
endurance, and gratitude,
I found all I needed
out of life

enough
for a life well lived

after 35,
all I want
is to keep my peace

35

A sum of a life
a sum of personas
a sum of experiences—
good and bad

a world of self,
and many I had the pleasure to meet

boy becomes man,
and man finds in the boy
a home, an essence,
the root of all he became

dreams fulfilled,
forgotten,
and undone

a marathon, not a race

the prize is not the end,
but what is won every day

35 is not the end,
but a checkpoint
in a game without retries

regrets and mistakes accepted
failures owned

with gratitude,
I danced with my demons
until they dissolved

by God

I am here—blessed
with love and pride

a life well lived

About the Author

John Muconto is a programmer and writer from Mozambique with professional experience in IT management and a parallel academic background in theology. His work sits at the intersection of analytical systems thinking and reflective spiritual inquiry.

He has practiced the Messianic faith for 22 years, a perspective that informs much of his worldview and writing.

His poetry collection, *35 Poems*, reflects structured introspection, personal observation, and thematic exploration of meaning, discipline, and belief.

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